

devices were much better equipped, with bigger colour displays and faster processors that could handle more tasks.

With the entry of 2G services such as GPRS and WAP in India, being connected on the go also became a reality. Users were now able to access Internet content from just about anywhere in a mobile provider's service area. This has changed life for many of us, even if it means staying signed in to IM services such as Yahoo! Messenger, or being able to access e-mail from anywhere, at any time.

These services let you enjoy full-blown Internet access by connecting your phone to your laptop. Short-range wireless services such as Bluetooth or Wi-Fi also meant that communication between two users, or connecting to the Internet at, say, a coffee shop or an airport, was easier than ever before.

Though not as path-breaking as the PC or the Internet, mobile computing set us free from the shackles of wires and fixed terminals, and has forever changed the way we compute on the move.

Digital Entertainment

A little over a decade ago, VCRs, movie theatres and VCD players were our only source of entertainment. Sure, there was the TV, but what if you wanted to watch what you wanted to watch? Along came digital audio and video to forever



Microsoft's Media Center OS is catching up, proving that the PC is really becoming the entertainment solution in many homes

change the face of personal entertainment. The spotlight gradually shifted from the TV to the PC monitor, and today, even if we have a DVD player, we tend to pop a DVD movie into our DVD-ROM drive to watch it on the PC.

The most notable of the digital formats was perhaps MP3. This audio format, although not a lossless compression technique, was single-handedly responsible for bringing digital audio to the PC. It was developed and standardised in 1991 by a team working for the ISO/IEC MPEG audio committee, and we first started seeing .mp3 files sometime in 1995. With the popularisation of MP3 on the Internet, mainly due to the smaller file sizes and decent audio quality, piracy of audio CDs took off. Songs could be downloaded for the first time, even on lower bandwidth connections, and Napster ruled the Net.

A major contributing factor to the popularity of the MP3 file format was the fact that encoders and rippers were easily available, and could also run on lower-powered PCs. So just about anybody with a computer could pop in an audio CD and rip it to MP3, and also use P2P clients to share the songs with people across the world.

Though there are considerably better encoding formats such as AAC and Ogg Vorbis, and even lossless formats such as FLAC and Monkey's Audio, it will take considerable time for any other encoder to dethrone the MP3. Because of its popularity, most DVD and VCD players have incorporated MP3 support.

Almost every computer-literate has heard of the format, and many software media players bundle at least one MP3 song with their installers. If that weren't enough, a whole slew of portable music gadgets sprung up, and though they support most popular compressed audio formats, they have kept the title of "portable MP3 players".

In terms of video, it was perhaps DivX that popularised digital video on PCs. Though DivX was really a hit at one point, it does not enjoy a similar stranglehold on video compression as MP3 does on audio. It's controversial, but DivX perhaps helped boost the online pornography industry by allowing movies to be compressed and distributed via P2P and also Web sites.

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